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UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 215: Basic Film Analysis and Appreciation - Reading the Moving Image

From shot to sequence: how films mean what they mean

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Film analysis is close reading with a stopwatch. This pack teaches you to break a sequence into shots, analyse framing, movement, editing, sound and performance, and write an analysis that cites timecodes as evidence. It includes Nollywood and African cinema examples rather than a Hollywood-only canon.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Break a sequence into shots and describe each accurately.
- Analyse framing, camera movement, lighting and colour.
- Explain continuity, montage and editing rhythm.
- Write a timecode-based analysis of a short sequence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Mise-en-scene and cinematography

Everything in the frame is a decision.

- Mise-en-scene: setting, props, costume, performance and lighting within the frame.
- Framing: shot size, angle, headroom, composition and depth.
- Movement: pan, tilt, dolly, handheld and crane each carry a different feel.
- Lens and focus: wide lenses exaggerate space; long lenses compress it.
- Lighting: direction, contrast and colour temperature shape mood and meaning.
- Production design communicates period, class and character before dialogue begins.

Editing and sound

The cut is the basic unit of film grammar.

- Continuity editing preserves spatial and temporal logic for the viewer.
- Montage creates meaning through juxtaposition rather than continuity.
- Cutting rhythm controls pace and emotional pressure.
- Sound design: dialogue, ambience, effects and music; diegetic versus non-diegetic.
- Silence is a designed choice, not an absence.
- Sound bridges link scenes and smooth transitions.

> **Cite timecodes**
> '01:12:30 to 01:14:05' is evidence. 'The scene where she cries' is not. Timestamps make your argument checkable.

Writing the analysis

Structure beats adjectives.

1. State your claim about how the sequence produces meaning.
2. Describe the sequence's duration and position in the film.
3. Analyse two or three formal elements in detail.
4. Quote dialogue exactly and give timecodes.
5. Connect form to theme, genre or context.
6. Avoid plot summary except where it is necessary to your argument.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 215

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 215 Basic Film Analysis and Appreciation is named in the 2018 course description page
- Film study is grouped with media arts and broadcast production
- THA 333 Jingle and Effects Design and THA 252 production fundamentals are described nearby

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 215 Basic Film Analysis and Appreciation, 3 credits, first semester, 200 level
- Listed with THA 211 and THA 213 in the theory block
- Film studies later expands into THA 324 directing and THA 344 design for screen

What changed: The 2019 listing places film analysis in a theory block, with production following in the media courses.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Film analysis remains the 200-level entry to the film track in the compiled map
- The department name now includes Film Studies, so expect expanded screen examples
- Confirm whether analysis is assessed by exam, coursework or both

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish continuity editing from montage.

Answer: Continuity editing preserves coherent space and time; montage builds meaning through the juxtaposition of shots that may not be spatially continuous.

2. What does a low camera angle usually suggest?

Answer: Power, dominance or threat in the subject, depending on context.

3. Why are timecodes essential in film analysis?

Answer: They let a reader verify your evidence and locate the exact moment you are discussing.

4. Give an example of non-diegetic sound.

Answer: A musical score that the characters cannot hear, added to shape the audience's emotional response.

5. What is mise-en-scene?

Answer: Everything placed within the frame: setting, props, costume, lighting and performance.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Watch a five-minute sequence three times and log every shot.
- [ ] Write a shot list with timecodes and descriptions.
- [ ] Analyse lighting direction in two scenes.
- [ ] Compare continuity editing and montage using two examples.
- [ ] Draft a 500-word sequence analysis with timecodes.
- [ ] Watch one Nollywood film and one African art film and compare form.
- [ ] Peer-review a coursemate's analysis for evidence, not opinion.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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